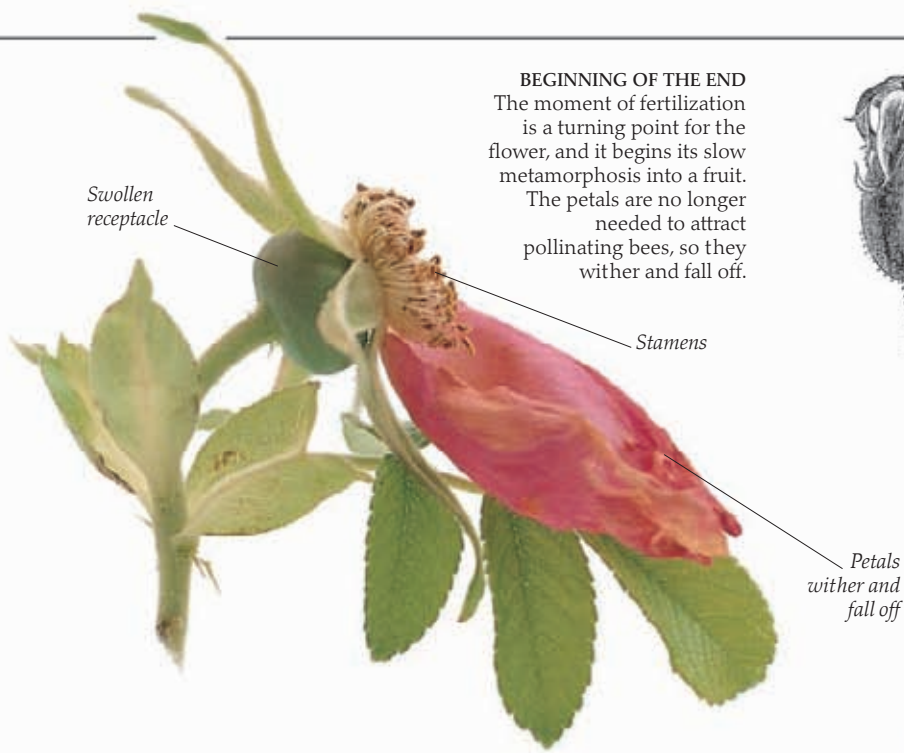
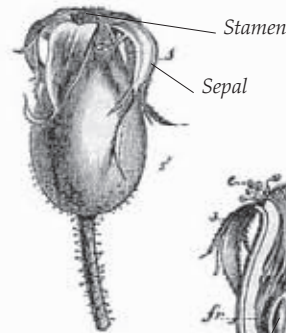
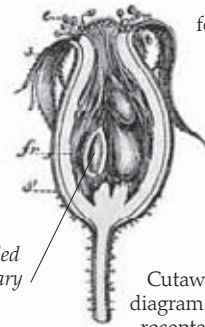




BEGINNING OF THE END
The moment of fertilization is a turning point for the flower, and it begins its slow metamorphosis into a fruit. The petals are no longer needed to attract pollinating bees, so they wither and fall off.



Seed, surrounded by an ovary



Cutaway diagram of a receptacle

INSIDE STORY
Inside the receptacle, there are a great many ovaries. Each contains an ovule, which requires its own pollen grain for fertilization. The fertilized ovule develops into a seed. These seeds are enveloped in a thin yet tough coat and are known in botanical terms as achenes. The rose hip contains many of these small achenes.



Swollen receptacle starts to change color

THE ROSE HIP
As the fertilized ovules develop into seeds called achenes, the receptacle swells and turns red. When ripe, it is called a rose hip.



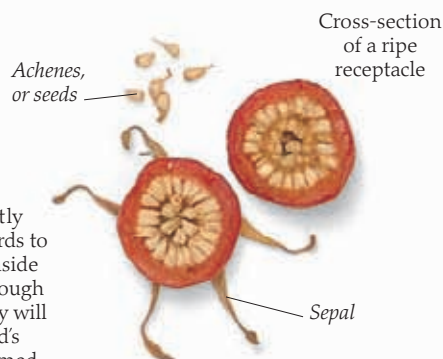
NATURAL CHEATS
Rose seeds are packed with nutrients to give the seedlings a good start in life. Some birds cheat the plant by eating the seeds, cracking them open to get at the food stores inside. Greenfinches do this, spurning the rose hip itself, which they leave hanging in tatters from the plant. The greenfinch gets a good meal, but in so doing it destroys the seeds rather than disperses them.



Receptacle contains vitamin C

USEFUL FRUITS

The achenes of the rose hip are covered in short, brittle hairs. A medicinal syrup made from rose hips is often given to babies and young children. Rose hips contain vitamin C, which helps protect against colds.



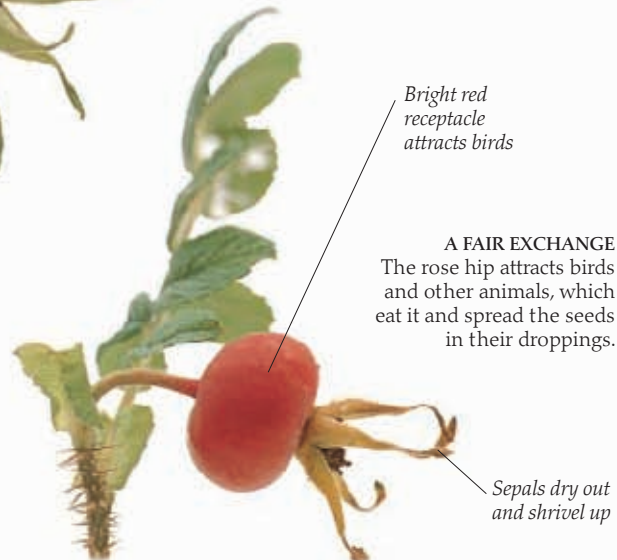
Achenes, or seeds

Cross-section of a ripe receptacle

Sepal

PRECIOUS CARGO

The rose hip is brightly colored, attracting birds to eat it. The achenes inside the receptacle have tough skins. With luck, they will pass through the bird's digestive tract unharmed.



Bright red receptacle attracts birds

A FAIR EXCHANGE
The rose hip attracts birds and other animals, which eat it and spread the seeds in their droppings.

Sepals dry out and shrivel up